



MONTHLY UPDATE

Gabon: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-10 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA

Summary of the month

Two systems failed and one was repaired. The national fibre backbone [suffered a massive outage on 25 August](#), and the civil service's single reference file for staff and payroll [was found near-inoperative, with an emergency restoration plan ordered on 25 August](#). Against them, the water and electricity utility [reported progressive recovery from the cyberattack that took down 95% of its systems, with billing and payment restored at Libreville](#).

The month's instruments were fiscal and regional. The supplementary finance law [brought in value added tax and a solidarity contribution on non-resident digital platforms](#), the advance passenger and passenger-name-record system [entered its operational phase](#), and a Libreville workshop [adopted a Central African roadmap for cross-border health-data sharing](#). An external assessment meanwhile [found the country not meeting minimum fiscal-transparency requirements](#).

Governance

Legislation and regulation

On 11 July nine civil-society organisations declared the broadcasting authority's social-media suspension unconstitutional, disproportionate and beyond its statutory remit, and demanded its abrogation; they also stated that a bill regulating social media exists and awaits promulgation ([declaration](#)). On 17 July the presidential spokesman defended the measure as temporary and conservatory and gave no lifting date. On 25 July an advocacy association presented a report built from two months of consultations, finding no transparent mechanism governing restriction of social networks and recommending revision of the ordinance of 8 April 2026 and greater independence for the broadcasting authority ([report](#)). On 13 August the national human-rights and democracy council took the opposite side of the same argument, [calling for judicial action against online outrage of the presidency and urging a CEMAC or continental legal framework for cyberspace modelled on the European Union's Digital Services Act](#).

On 23 July a national workshop validated by consensus five implementing texts on the digitalisation of teaching — two decrees, two orders and a decree creating a basic computing certificate — and forwarded them to the competent authorities with recommendations. They are technically validated and not adopted ([close of the workshop](#)).

The month's other legislative movement is procedural rather than expressive. A justice ministry commission [submitted a draft Code of Civil Procedure on 11 August](#), a rewrite of the 1977 ordinance running to more than 800 pages that would let procedural filings be made and held electronically, introduce secure digital tools, and harmonise with the OHADA uniform acts. Professional consultation and parliamentary debate are still ahead, and the draft text is not held.

An earlier instrument reached the base this month and it is the furthest-going measure of its kind reported in the region. An ordinance of February 2026 [fixes digital majority at 16 and obliges platforms to limit certain publication and interaction functions, to disable contacts from unidentified users by default and to provide age-verification mechanisms](#) — a duty on how a platform is built rather than a minimum age alone, where Rwanda is still preparing a restriction on under-16s and Zimbabwe has gone the policy route. The ordinance text is not held, only a comparative account of it, and no implementing regulation, supervisory body or enforcement action is on record.

The primary text of the social-media ordinance arrived, and it settles a conflation the base had carried. [Ordonnance n 0011/PR/2026](#), signed on 26 February 2026 and published in Journal Officiel n 110 of 8 April 2026, is the instrument the base had recorded twice — once as an ordinance whose text was not held and once as a bill reported second-hand to be awaiting promulgation. It runs to fifty-five articles in eleven chapters: digital majority is fixed at sixteen and account creation below it barred; editors must block publication, sharing and social-interaction functions for accounts identified as under-sixteen without recorded parental consent, disable by default any function letting unidentified persons contact a minor, filter algorithmic recommendation of violent, sexual or psychologically harmful AI content to minor accounts, and report quarterly to the competent authority; age-verification systems sit under a Haute Autorite de la Communication reference framework and a technical audit; and the refere numerique caps any temporary suspension of access to a platform at seventy-two hours. The twelve-month compliance clock runs from publication, to 8 April 2027.

Gabon also [brought non-resident digital platforms within Value Added Tax and the Contribution Speciale de Solidarite](#) through its 2026 supplementary finance law, reaching foreign streaming and platform services. No registration threshold, collection mechanism or first receipt is on file.

Data protection

The data protection authority described itself, which is the most the record holds about it. Its president [set out the mandate and its limits: the authority holds a regulatory power to set rules published in the official journal, personal data remains the property of the citizen while collectors hold and process it, and insult and digital communication fall outside its competence and to the media regulator — which is what it is most often asked about](#). He put dealing directly with the large social platforms as requiring a common African response rather than a national one. No budget, staffing, caseload or enforcement action for the authority is published, so its independence is asserted rather than evidenced.

Regional collaboration

Two outward moves in the same week, one to learn and one to be heard. An interior, security and decentralisation ministry delegation [spent nearly two weeks in Rwanda on digital transformation and e-governance, artificial intelligence and digital policy, civil-registration and identification digitisation, cybersecurity, data protection, interconnection of public systems and decentralised service digitisation](#) - the longest and widest-ranging of eight delegations the host received that week. Separately the digital economy minister [presented the country's candidacy for the International Telecommunication Union Council in Nassau on 3 September, under the slogan Shaping the Digital Future](#). Neither carries an agreement, an adoption decision or a campaign platform beyond the slogan.

Standards

Service quality is the one obligation the base cannot show being enforced. Reporting of 25 August 2026 states that at a departmental capital, a commune since 1996 with a prefecture, town hall and schools, [the incumbent sells data bundles on a network whose coverage appears and disappears while prepaid credit and bundle validity run down normally, and puts the regulator's inaction to the president of its regulatory council](#). No quality-of-service determination, decision or sanction is published, which is why the row stands here as *Not held*.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The regulator [established a tripartite dialogue forum at Libreville on 20 August](#), seating itself, the operators and consumers. It is the first standing consultation channel the base holds for this sector, and no meeting schedule, published minutes or complaints route follows from the announcement.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

On 27 July the Libreville seminar on space communications closed with eleven recommendations, confirming a hybrid fibre and satellite model on [2,000 km of fibre already deployed](#).

The national internet exchange point opened a reboot workshop at Libreville on 3 August, running to 8 August, with the Internet Society and AFRINIC as technical partners ([opening](#)). It [closed on 8 August with certificates presented after six days of peering, security and sovereignty training](#); AFRINIC called for a network of trained ambassadors to carry the skills into firms and administrations, and operator representatives named broader institutional buy-in as the task that remains. No participant number and no post-relaunch member count has been published.

Cybersecurity

The utility [restored billing and payment in Libreville and seven interior centres after the attack that took down 95% of its systems](#), describing its network on 4 August as healthy, secured and protected by reinforced measures, with restoration continuing elsewhere. The account is the company's own, the attackers are described as unidentified, and no forensic, criminal or damage-cost report is on file.

An audit that was signed in May reported in August. The state digital agency [delivered its information-systems audit findings to the health insurance fund on 12 August](#), three months after the two signed the memorandum, naming human resources, data and infrastructure as the three pillars of the fund's technology roadmap. The findings themselves are not published, and no remediation plan, timetable or cost is stated.

DPI

Data Exchange

The regional interoperable QR-code standard was launched at Douala on 29 July 2026 under the monetary union regulation of 8 April 2026, in force across all six member states and settled through the regional switch, with the Gabonese scheme as its pilot ([launch](#)). The switch's 2025 figures, presented the following day, were 20.3m transactions worth FCFA 863bn across 153 participants ([figures](#)). On 9 July the central bank acceded to the pan-African payment and settlement system, with member-state banks to be connected by the end of 2026 ([announcement](#)).

A different kind of exchange went live in August. The airport-security committee [moved its advance passenger information and passenger-name-record system into its operational phase on 14 August](#), naming Royal Air Maroc lead carrier for IATA-code implementation under the state's convention with SECURIPOINT, with border risk-screening the stated purpose. The convention terms, the retention rule for passenger data and any authorisation by the data-protection authority are not held — and the country's biometric-processing prohibition, with the defect already recorded in its derogation, sits alongside it unremarked.

The private half of the health system was brought into a standing channel for the first time. The health ministry [instituted quarterly consultations with the association of private health establishments, the agenda naming the transmission of health data from private clinics among its items](#). No data standard, transmission route, reporting obligation or first meeting date is published, and the base holds no measure of what share of care the private sector accounts for — so the channel exists and what will flow through it does not.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A bus fare is about to become a biometric credential. The national transport company is [preparing a biometric transport card for Libreville buses, securing the collection of personal data before digitising access to the service](#). No issuance date, data controller, retention rule or fare structure is stated.

Registries

A domestic commentary put the governance question on transport digitalisation in public: it places the [digitalisation of transport titles and documents among the state's modernisation projects and asks who governs it and whether local suppliers are used](#). It is an opinion piece rather than a programme document — no contracting authority, supplier, scope, cost or timetable is on the record — which is why it reaches this report as the only account of a project the state has not described.

Sectoral management information systems

On 30 July the education ministry received 1,000 tablets for what the minister described as 148 connected schools ([handover](#)).

The state's civil-service human-resources record has been failing for months. The Fichier unique de reference is [near-inoperative, blocking tenure confirmations, reclassifications, recruitments and promotions and stopping their pay effects reaching agents, the breakdown sitting in the data-replication link between the civil service and pay services](#); on 25 August the vice-president of the government ordered an emergency plan restoring career management, agent mobility and data replication. The civil service ministry says it is migrating to an integrated state human-resources management system.

The education ministry's priorities for the new school year restate the delivery counts: [1,000 tablets and 500 interactive screens delivered over 2025-2026, with the digital rollout continuing into 2026-2027](#). These are the ministry's own device counts and nothing is published against them for learner reach, usage or maintenance — the same shape the connected-schools figures have carried all year.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

On 2 August the border agency's tourist electronic visa platform, developed in 2025, was presented to the travel trade ([account](#)). A second platform was shown rather than launched: administration.ga was [presented to the Vice-President as an integrated suite for secure messaging, meeting management and the exchange of confidential documents between civil servants, built with a Gabonese start-up, with the state holding the source code at no cost](#). No contract, cost, timetable or hosting arrangement is stated.

Technology

AI

An operator [launched a voice artificial-intelligence service reachable by dialling 333 from an ordinary feature phone](#), with no smartphone and no internet connection required. Delivering an AI service over the voice channel reaches the part of the population a data-only service does not; no user count, language coverage or tariff is published.

ICT Industry

A ride-hailing platform [began recruiting drivers at Libreville in partnership with a local transport operator, without announcing a launch date, the cities it will serve, its tariffs or its regulatory framework](#). It works as a pure intermediary with no fleet or drivers of its own, entering a market where one competitor has operated since 2021 and electric taxis were deployed in late 2025 under a state-backed project.

Innovation ecosystem

The open-innovation programme was launched on 14 July 2026 with the employers' federation, addressing a population the organisers put at 150 to 200 start-ups, with pre-selection on 24 July and a final on 4 August ([launch](#)). The final was postponed on 6 August after participating start-ups objected to how the edition was organised, and a [revised agenda published on 11 August](#) runs pitches to 24 August and moves the final to late September or early October. The same account gives the programme's first participation figures: 155 registered start-ups, 133 of which submitted against its 16 published challenges, and 66 shortlisted. The figures are the organisers' own and no laureate list or selection criteria has been published.

On 4 July, at the data-centre inauguration, the ministry and the facility's operator signed a memorandum giving ministry-supported start-ups professional hosting at preferential rates ([account](#)). No rate, eligibility list or take-up figure has been published.

The state digital incubator was not closed after all. It [has been placed under interim management, a deputy director general of the state holding that owns 30 per cent of its capital taking the post pending a new model, with a state takeover, conversion to a parapublic entity, absorption into the national innovation centre or supervision by the holding all under discussion](#); the digital economy ministry is to decide.

Capacity

Training and skills

Certification training is [under way for participants at Libreville's American Corner under a digital-skills programme run with United States embassies](#). No cohort size or completion date is published.

More than 130 young people have been [trained in cybersecurity, networks, artificial intelligence and programming since June 2026](#) under a programme with the United States. No curriculum, certification or placement outcome is published.

Inclusion

Access to services

The communications regulator [put its consumer short code 1331 back in service after a period of unavailability, announced at a 20 August meeting with operators and consumer associations](#), and set out the route a complaint takes: to the operator first, then to the regulator, with quality incidents reported through an application. A reactivation says what the position was before it. No complaint volume or resolution figure is published, and no national feedback portal exists.

Data

National statistics

On 21 July an interministerial committee fixed the terms of a second census of economically weak Gabonese, with preparation through July and August and fieldwork from September 2026, drawing on the population census and health-insurance records; its stated purpose is that the existing social file is not reliable enough to target protection ([terms](#)).

Open data

Gabon was assessed again as [not meeting the minimum fiscal transparency requirements in the 2026 review, published 11 August 2026 for the period to 31 December 2025, which presses governments to publish and regularly update information on state financial obligations including those of major state-owned enterprises](#). Of 139 governments and one entity reviewed, 73 met the requirements and 67 did not.

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